

COLLABORATIVE APPROACHES TOWARDS STRENGTHENING SECURITY AND REGIONAL STABILITY IN THE NORTH CENTRAL OF NIGERIA

A 30-Minute Presentation to Governors, Military Veterans,
Traditional Leaders and Other Critical Stakeholders

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1. PROTOCOLS

Your Excellencies, the Executive Governors of the North Central States; distinguished former Chiefs of Service and other senior military and security officers; our revered Royal Fathers and Traditional Leaders; honourable

members of the National and State Assemblies; distinguished leaders of thought, community leaders, religious leaders, women and youth representatives; members of the business community, civil society and the media; ladies and gentlemen — I am deeply honoured to address this distinguished gathering on a subject that concerns not merely the North Central, but the very survival, unity and future of Nigeria.

Our subject today is “Collaborative Approaches Towards Strengthening Security and Regional Stability in the North Central of Nigeria.” I deliberately use the word collaborative, because the security crisis before us cannot be solved by the military alone, the police alone, governors alone, traditional rulers alone, or communities alone. It requires all of us, working together, with a common purpose and a shared responsibility.

2. INTRODUCTION: UNDERSTANDING THE NORTH CENTRAL

The North Central is commonly understood within Nigeria's six geopolitical-zone framework as comprising Benue, Kogi, Kwara, Nasarawa, Niger and Plateau States, together with the Federal Capital Territory. But the North Central is much more than an administrative description on a map. It is a strategic geographical bridge connecting Nigeria's North and South, East and West, and it is also a meeting ground of peoples, cultures, religions, languages, agricultural systems and historical traditions. The region is home to numerous ethnic nationalities, including the Tiv, Idoma, Iggede, Jukun, Igala, Ebira, Nupe, Gbagyi, Berom, Afizere, Anaguta, Mwaghavul, Goemai, Eggon, Mada and many others. This

diversity is one of the region's greatest assets. It can also become a source of tension when poorly managed.

Geographically, the North Central possesses extraordinary diversity. It contains major river systems, fertile agricultural belts, forests, grazing areas, mineral deposits, hills and expansive rural communities. The River Niger and River Benue systems are particularly important to the economic and ecological life of Nigeria, and the region also contains major transportation corridors linking different parts of the country. In strategic terms, therefore, what happens in the North Central rarely remains confined to the North Central. Instability here can disrupt national transportation, food supply, internal migration, commerce and national security.

Historically, the Middle Belt and North Central have been a zone of interaction among many peoples and civilisations. Pre-colonial political formations, including the Kwararafa traditions and other indigenous political systems, demonstrate that the peoples of this broad region have long interacted through migration, trade, warfare, diplomacy, intermarriage and cultural exchange. The colonial period subsequently imposed new administrative boundaries, and independence and subsequent state creation further transformed the political geography. The result is today's complex North Central: many peoples, many histories, many identities — but one strategic Nigerian space. That diversity must not be treated as a weakness. It should become the foundation of a new model of Nigerian coexistence.

3. THE PLACE OF NORTH CENTRAL IN NIGERIA'S UNITY AND DEVELOPMENT

The greatest resource of the North Central is not its minerals. It is its people. The region possesses a population

deeply connected to agriculture, livestock, commerce, public service, military service, education and entrepreneurship, and its communities have historically contributed significantly to the Nigerian Armed Forces and other security institutions. The North Central has therefore not merely occupied geographical space within Nigeria. It has helped build Nigeria.

The North Central also constitutes one of Nigeria's most important agricultural zones. Its agricultural potential spans food crops, livestock, fisheries, tree crops, grains, tubers, fruits and vegetables, and vast areas suitable for modern commercial agriculture. Nigeria's food-security strategy cannot succeed while insecurity continues to drive farmers from their farms. A farmer who cannot safely cultivate his land is not merely a victim of insecurity; he is also a casualty of Nigeria's economic crisis, and every abandoned farm has consequences for food prices, inflation, employment and national stability.

The region also possesses substantial mineral resources, including deposits of tin, columbite, iron ore, limestone, coal, barite and lead-zinc. Niger State contains enormous hydroelectric and agricultural potential; Kogi possesses major mineral and agricultural resources; Benue is one of Nigeria's major agricultural belts; Plateau has exceptional agricultural and tourism potential; Nasarawa possesses significant solid-mineral resources; Kwara has agricultural, industrial and commercial potential; and the Federal Capital Territory remains Nigeria's political and administrative centre. The strategic question therefore is not whether the North Central possesses resources — it does. The question is whether we can create the security environment in which those resources can be transformed into prosperity.

The North Central occupies a unique position in national security precisely because of this endowment. It borders or connects several major regions of Nigeria, and it contains important highways, agricultural corridors, forests, waterways and rural settlements. Consequently, insecurity in the North Central creates a national security multiplier effect: it can facilitate the movement of armed groups, disrupt food production, displace communities, allow criminal exploitation of ungoverned spaces, fuel arms trafficking and communal violence, destroy economic infrastructure, and weaken public confidence in government. The security of the North Central is therefore not a regional matter alone. It is a national security imperative.

4. THE REGION'S PECULIAR SECURITY CHALLENGES

The first requirement for solving a conflict is to correctly understand it. One of our problems has been the temptation to reduce the North Central crisis to a single label. Is it a farmers-herders conflict? Is it communal conflict? Is it terrorism? Is it banditry? Is it land conflict? Is it resource competition? Is it political violence? The uncomfortable answer is that it can be all of these at different times and in different locations, and we therefore need a more sophisticated conflict architecture.

That architecture contains interconnected layers. First, there is competition over land and natural resources, as population growth, climate variability, shrinking grazing corridors, expanding cultivation and changing settlement patterns have all increased pressure on land. Second, there is criminality and banditry, as armed criminal networks

exploit weakly governed spaces, forests and difficult terrain. Third, there is terrorism and extremist influence, and where terrorist networks establish links with criminal networks, local conflicts can acquire a wider security dimension. Fourth, there is communal and identity-based violence, where historical grievances, ethnic suspicion and political competition can turn local disputes into large-scale violence. Fifth, there is the proliferation of small arms and light weapons, which increases the lethality of otherwise manageable disputes. And sixth, there are weak justice and accountability mechanisms: where perpetrators repeatedly escape justice, communities increasingly resort to self-help, and once communities begin organising for self-defence outside a coordinated legal framework, the security environment can deteriorate further.

These are not abstract categories. In December 2023, over one hundred and forty people were killed across more than seventeen rural communities in Plateau State in a single coordinated wave of Christmas Eve attacks, and barely a month later, in January 2024, at least thirty more people were killed in further attacks around Mangu town. This was not a one-off spike: between May 2023 and May 2025, one thousand and forty-three people were killed in Benue State alone, and the single deadliest recent incident came on the night of the thirteenth and fourteenth of June 2025, when the Yelwata massacre in Guma Local Government Area of Benue State killed at least one hundred and fifty to one hundred and sixty people in one night — an incident so severe that Nigeria formally charged nine men with terrorism over it, and one that moved even Pope Leo to publicly pray for the victims at his Sunday Angelus.

This pattern has not eased in 2026. Data compiled by the Berom Youth Moulders Association and reviewed by

HumAngle recorded one hundred and twenty-one people killed in Plateau State alone between May and the eleventh of July 2026 — sixty-two in May, forty-three in June, and sixteen in the first eleven days of July — across Barkin Ladi, Riyom, Bassa, Jos South and Pankshin Local Government Areas. A single weekend in July saw at least eighteen more killed across Benue and Plateau together, including an entire family murdered in Kum, in Riyom Local Government Area. Then, in August 2026, an attack around Kpenya and Dekara in the Borgu area of Niger State resulted in reports of sixty to eighty people abducted, with subsequent video evidence reportedly showing as many as six hundred women, children and elderly people held by armed men — a figure the authorities were still verifying — alongside roughly thirty killed and some two thousand residents displaced toward the Benin Republic border. Nationally, SBM Intelligence recorded seven thousand, eight hundred and twenty-five kidnapping victims between July 2025 and June 2026, with at least one thousand, one hundred and forty-two people killed, and more than seven point seven eight billion naira paid out in ransom during that period alone. This is why I insist we treat the human cost here as a development emergency, and not merely a law-and-order problem — it is lost harvests, interrupted schooling, ransom economies, and a generation growing up distrustful of the state's capacity to protect it.

The ultimate measurement of insecurity is not the number of operations conducted. It is the condition of the people. As of the thirty-first of December 2024, five hundred thousand, one hundred and eighty-two people were already living in displacement camps in Benue State alone, and by October 2025, North-Central and North-West Nigeria combined were hosting one million, three hundred and seventy-eight thousand, one hundred and twenty-four internally displaced

persons. Behind these figures sit deaths, destroyed homes, abandoned farms, disrupted education, reduced investment, trauma, lost livelihoods, declining rural economies and weakened trust between communities and government.

There is another consequence that deserves greater attention: the erosion of social trust. When a farmer fears a pastoralist, a pastoralist fears a farming community, one ethnic group fears another, and citizens distrust security institutions, the foundation of society begins to fracture. Security therefore cannot be reduced to weapons and personnel. Security is ultimately about trust.

5. THE JOURNEY TOWARDS A SUSTAINABLE SOLUTION

Governments have not been inactive. The Nigerian military and other security agencies have conducted numerous operations. State governments have established various security initiatives. Traditional rulers have mediated conflicts. Communities have developed local peace mechanisms, and civil society organisations, religious institutions and development partners have also contributed. Yet the persistence of the crisis tells us something important: we have many interventions, but insufficient integration. We have security agencies operating alongside one another, governments operating at different levels, traditional institutions, communities, intelligence institutions, civil society and humanitarian agencies — but too often, these actors operate in parallel rather than as parts of one coherent security ecosystem. That must change.

The North Central requires a decisive philosophical shift: from reaction to prevention, from fragmentation to

coordination, from secrecy to appropriate intelligence-sharing, from military dominance to whole-of-society security, and from temporary operations to a sustainable security architecture. The military should remain available for threats that exceed civilian capacity, but soldiers cannot permanently replace police, local government, community leadership, intelligence institutions, justice systems and development agencies. A lasting solution requires every institution to perform its proper function.

6. A COLLABORATIVE FRAMEWORK FOR SECURITY AND REGIONAL STABILITY

I propose a North Central Collaborative Security and Stability Framework, built on six pillars.

The first pillar is a regional security coordination mechanism. Governors of the North Central should establish a permanent regional security coordination platform working with the Federal Government, military commands, police, intelligence agencies, civil defence, traditional institutions, local governments and community representatives, with the purpose of facilitating lawful information sharing, early warning, joint planning and coordinated responses. This should not create another parallel security agency; rather, it should improve coordination among institutions that already exist. This is also the moment to note a genuinely significant development unfolding at the federal level: in February 2026 President Bola Ahmed Tinubu publicly urged the Senate to amend the constitution to accommodate state police, and in June 2026 he formally transmitted the Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria (Alteration) (State Police) Bill, 2026, to the National Assembly. Both

chambers have since passed their respective versions, and harmonisation is under way — one of the most significant security reforms in Nigeria's democratic history, and one that must be built on exactly the coordinated foundation this pillar describes, not layered on top of six uncoordinated command structures.

The second pillar is intelligence-led security. The future of security is intelligence: we must know who is moving, where they are moving, what their intention is, where their supply lines run, where vulnerable communities sit, and where conflicts are emerging. The region needs stronger integration of human intelligence, aerial surveillance, lawful communications intelligence, geospatial intelligence, community reporting, incident databases and intelligence fusion. But technology must support, not replace, human intelligence. A traditional ruler often knows what is happening in his domain before Abuja does; a farmer knows unusual movement in his community; a local trader may recognise strangers; a village youth may know a forest path that does not appear on a government map. The challenge is to build a system where such information can safely and lawfully reach the appropriate authorities.

The third pillar is community-based early warning and early response. Every local government should have a structured early-warning mechanism, in which traditional rulers, religious leaders, women, youth, farmers, pastoralist representatives, local officials and security agencies have established channels for reporting emerging tensions. The objective is simple: do not wait for a conflict to become a massacre before responding. If intelligence indicates that two communities are mobilising for confrontation, intervention should begin at the warning stage, because conflict prevention is cheaper than conflict management,

and conflict management is cheaper than reconstruction. We already know that a linked model works: the Early Warning and Early Response system operating in Kaduna and Katsina states has reportedly mitigated one hundred and twenty-six flagged conflict cases. That is proof that when detection is paired with a trusted, funded response chain, it saves lives, and our task is simply to extend that exact model into the North Central states we are discussing today.

The fourth pillar is securing the rural economy. We cannot secure the North Central while leaving its farms and rural communities vulnerable, and we therefore need protected agricultural corridors. This does not mean militarising agriculture; it means creating a predictable security environment in which farmers can cultivate and pastoralists can move lawfully, through clearly defined land-use arrangements, protection of farming communities, lawful livestock movement systems, negotiated grazing and ranching solutions where appropriate, water access, livestock identification and tracking, rapid response to attacks, and effective dispute-resolution mechanisms. The objective should be competition management, not ethnic confrontation.

The fifth pillar recognises traditional institutions as security partners. Traditional rulers remain one of the most important underutilised assets in Nigeria's security architecture, and their legitimacy is often deeper than that of modern political institutions at the community level. They know the history of their communities, family relationships, migration patterns, traditional boundaries, the sources of conflict, and the individuals capable of mediating disputes. Government should therefore create formal mechanisms for traditional rulers to participate in early warning, mediation,

reconciliation and community mobilisation — but traditional institutions should not be turned into vigilante commands. Their strength is legitimacy, mediation and social intelligence.

The sixth pillar is justice, development and reconstruction. There can be no lasting security without justice: where citizens believe that perpetrators will never be punished, violence becomes rationalised. We therefore need faster investigation, effective prosecution, protection of witnesses, stronger community-level dispute resolution, land and boundary dispute mechanisms, compensation and reconstruction mechanisms, and reintegration programmes where appropriate. At the same time, development must follow security: when a community is liberated from armed groups but receives no school, clinic, road, water or economic opportunity, insecurity can return. Security without development is fragile. Development without security is impossible.

Comparative experience from other conflict environments confirms that successful conflict management rarely depends on military force alone. Local ownership matters, because peace imposed from outside rarely lasts and communities must own the solution. Intelligence integration matters, because security agencies must share actionable information within lawful frameworks. Clear command and responsibility matter, because multiple agencies without clear responsibility produce gaps. Protection of civilians matters, because the population must see security forces as protectors, not merely combatants. Justice matters, because impunity encourages repetition. Economic recovery matters, because people must have something to lose by returning to violence. And dialogue matters, because

dialogue is not weakness — dialogue is a security instrument.

Your Excellencies, governors occupy a unique position at the intersection of politics, administration, development and security. The governor understands the political environment; the military commander understands operational security; the traditional ruler understands the community; the intelligence officer understands threats; the development expert understands socioeconomic drivers. The critical question is how we make these capabilities work as one system — and that is the essence of collaboration.

We should also deliberately harness the enormous experience of retired military and security personnel. Nigeria has produced generations of officers and men with expertise in intelligence, leadership, logistics, aviation, communications, civil-military relations, strategic planning and conflict management. Veterans should not be viewed merely as retired personnel; they are a national strategic reservoir of knowledge, and a properly constituted advisory mechanism could provide governments with independent professional perspectives without interfering with the constitutional chain of command.

Ultimately, no security architecture can succeed against the will of the people, and communities must become active partners — but community participation must be carefully structured. We should avoid the uncontrolled proliferation of armed groups; community security initiatives should operate within Nigerian law, under appropriate government supervision and with clear accountability. The principle should be community intelligence, not community warfare.

I propose that the North Central states consider a North Central Security and Stability Compact built around ten commitments: shared intelligence and early warning; joint security planning; protection of strategic agricultural corridors; coordinated border and forest security; strengthening of traditional mediation structures; rapid response to emerging communal conflicts; joint action against criminal networks; improved prosecution and justice mechanisms; post-conflict reconstruction and resettlement; and regular assessment of security performance. The compact should carry measurable indicators, so that we can honestly ask whether attacks are decreasing, whether farmers are returning to their farms, whether displaced communities are returning home, whether conflict warnings are being acted upon, whether perpetrators are being prosecuted, and whether communities trust security institutions more than they did before. If we cannot measure improvement, we cannot honestly claim success.

Distinguished guests, there is a deeper issue beneath the weapons, forests, farms and politics. It is trust. A community that trusts another community is less likely to mobilise against it. A citizen who trusts the police is more likely to provide intelligence. A traditional ruler who trusts government is more likely to cooperate. A pastoralist who trusts that his rights will be protected is less likely to seek protection outside the law. A farmer who trusts that the state will protect him is more likely to remain on his land. Therefore, our ultimate security objective should be building a society in which citizens believe that the state can protect them and that justice can resolve their grievances.

7. CONCLUSION

Distinguished governors, Royal Fathers, military veterans, security professionals, ladies and gentlemen — the North Central is standing at a crossroads. One path leads towards deeper fragmentation: more displacement, more communal suspicion, more abandoned farms, more weapons, more criminality, and ultimately a weakening of the Nigerian state. The other path leads towards cooperation: strong institutions, intelligence-led security, community participation, economic development, justice, reconciliation and regional stability. The choice is ours.

We must also recognise one fundamental reality: no single institution can save the North Central. Not the military. Not the police. Not the governors. Not the traditional rulers. Not the communities. But together, we can. The North Central should therefore become a model of a new Nigerian security philosophy — one that combines the strength of the armed forces, the legitimacy of traditional institutions, the authority of elected governments, the knowledge of local communities and the power of modern intelligence and technology.

Let us move from merely responding to insecurity to preventing it. Let us move from managing crises to eliminating their drivers. Let us move from suspicion to structured dialogue. Let us move from isolated state responses to regional cooperation. And above all, let us recognise that security is not simply the absence of violence. Security is when the farmer can return to his farm, when the child can go to school without fear, when the trader can travel safely, when communities can coexist without suspicion, when the traditional ruler can mediate without fear, when investors can commit their capital with confidence, and when every citizen believes that Nigeria belongs to him or her.

That is the North Central we should build. That is the Nigeria we should leave for the next generation. The time has come to secure the North Central — not merely for the North Central, but for Nigeria. Thank you, and God bless the Federal Republic of Nigeria.

8. REFERENCES

All dated incidents referenced above are drawn from public reporting, listed here in Harvard style. If challenged on any figure during Q&A, these are the citations to reference. Flag to your team if formal citation-grade sourcing with exact article links is needed ahead of the event.

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